MODULE

# 4 CRITICAL RESPONSE *to* ACADEMIC ARGUMENTS

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# Part 1 – Listening Strategies

University students are often engaged in structured group discussions on current, controversial, and academic topics in class, which can be part of the assessment (e.g., a panel discussion in University English II). These discussions require them to articulate their own viewpoints while presenting counterarguments to challenge their peers' claims.

By the end of this module, you should learn how to effectively summarise speakers' arguments and construct counterarguments, enabling more rigorous analysis and thorough exploration of various academic topics in group discussions.

In this module, you will listen to excerpts from group discussions addressing current academic topics. Each discussion will begin with relevant background information, including the topic's context and key definitions, and a brief description of the central controversies surrounding the topic. Your tasks are to:

- summarise the speaker's position and claim with accuracy to ensure group understanding, and
- develop and present a counterargument that identifies logical or evidentiary limitations in the speaker's claim.

**Purpose of this Section**: You will learn to identify macro-level discourse markers or signposting phrases to analyse the structure of the group discussion and the logical development of claims.

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## Activity 1.1: Brainstorming about Mindfulness

**Step 1**: Have you heard of the term "mindfulness"? How is it related to our daily lives?

**Step 2**: Watch a video to learn more about mindfulness and how we practise it.

**Self-Awareness for Kids | What is Mindfulness? | Mindfulness Meditation for Kids**

(https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jDpPhMES7Bc&t=2s)

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## Activity 1.2: Signposting Phrases

**Step 1**: Match the signposting phrases in column B with the appropriate component in a group discussion in column A.

| A. Component | | B. Signposting Phrase |
|---|---|---|
| a) Establishing Context<br><br>b) Defining Concepts | (  ) | *"Many people appreciate…, but now people…"* |
| | | *"Although supporters claim that..., critics argue that…"* |
| | | *"While its proponents believe…, a growing body of critics are…"* |
| c) Introducing Focus of Controversy | (  ) | *"Basically, (something) is about…"* |
| | | *"X can be defined as..."* |
| | | *"Essentially, it is a type of (something) used to …"* |
| d) Making Claims<br><br>e) Providing Evidence | (  ) | *"You may have heard about..."* |
| | | *"Since (year)…"* |
| | | *"There is a common phenomenon that…"* |
| f) Giving Explanations (e.g., Reasoning/ Elaboration) | (  ) | *"One key reason…"* |
| | | *"Supporters of (something) emphasise…"* |
| | | *"The main point here is that…"* |
| | (  ) | *"What this means is…"* |
| | | *"This leads to…"* |
| | | *"This suggests that…"* |
| | (  ) | *"Findings from (source) have shown that…"* |
| | | *"Research shows that..."* |
| | | *"According to (source)…"* |

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**Step 2**: You are going to listen to a discussion. While listening, put a tick "✓" next to the signposting phrases used in the discussion.

| A. Component | B. Signposting Phrases |
|---|---|
| • Establishing Context | *"You may have heard about..."* |
| | *"Since (year)…"* |
| | *"There is a common phenomenon that…"* |
| • Defining Concepts | *"Basically, (something) is about…"* |
| | *"X can be defined as..."* |
| | *"Essentially, it is a type of (something) used to …"* |
| • Introducing focus of controversy | *"Many people appreciate…, but now people …"* |
| | *"Although supporters claim that.., critics argue that…"* |
| | *"While its proponents believe…, a growing body of critics are…"* |
| • Making Claims | *"One key reason…"* |
| | *"Supporters of (something) emphasise…"* |
| | *"The main point here is that…"* |
| • Providing Evidence | *"Findings from (source) have shown that…"* |
| | *"Research shows that..."* |
| | *"According to (source)…"* |
| • Giving Explanations (e.g., Reasoning/ Elaboration) | *"What this means is…"* |
| | *"This leads to…"* |
| | *"This suggests that…"* |

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Step 3: The recording will be played again. While listening, highlight other signposting phrases.

**Tapescript**

[Narration] Since the late 2010s—especially after the pandemic—mindfulness has become a common practice in schools, clinics, and workplaces. Basically, it's about paying attention to your body, thoughts, and feelings in the present moment, on purpose and without judgement. Many people appreciate how accessible it is with short-guided sessions delivered through apps or brief classes at work, but now people are starting to wonder about how effective it really is in large organisations. Nonetheless, during a group discussion with her classmates, Lillian argues that mindfulness significantly improves employees' productivity. Here's what she said:

[Lillian's claim] One key reason mindfulness increases employees' productivity is that it helps them remain focussed on their tasks. Findings from systematic reviews have shown that mindfulness is associated with a decrease in stress caused by distractions and overthinking. This decrease can then lead to gains in thinking ability, motivation, and attention, as well as executive functioning in the workplace. In one specific case, a company that offered brief daily mindfulness sessions found that employees reported fewer interruptions and completed routine tasks more quickly with fewer errors. This doesn't surprise me because when workers notice their mind wandering and gently bring it back, they waste less time ruminating and switch back to the task sooner. Besides this, mindfulness practice can be done in short sessions between meetings, so employees can reset their attention without leaving their desks. With something like deadline pressure, even after a one-minute breathing exercise, a person might feel calmer and prioritise better. This suggests that the improved focus and self-regulation from mindfulness can lead to faster task completion, higher-quality output, and more efficient teamwork.

**Step 4**: Discuss how the signposting phrases guide the argument's logic.

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**Other Useful Signposting Phrases**

| Component | Signposting Phrase |
|---|---|
| *Background* (Context) | • ***In recent years***, *mindfulness has gained popularity as a tool for stress reduction in workplaces and schools.*<br>• ***Over the past decade***, *clinical studies have increasingly explored mindfulness as a complementary therapy for anxiety and chronic pain.*<br>• ***Nowadays***, *mindfulness apps and online courses make the practice accessible to millions of people worldwide.* |
| *Background* (Definition) | • *Mindfulness is the practice of focussing on the present moment without judgement.* ***In other words***, *it is about being fully aware of your thoughts, feelings, and surroundings while maintaining a calm, accepting attitude.*<br>• *According to American Psychological Association, mindfulness* ***is defined as*** *"awareness of one's internal states and surroundings".*<br>• *Mindfulness* ***refers to*** *the act of observing one's thoughts and sensations in the present moment to achieve greater emotional balance.* |
| *Focus of Controversy* | • ***A growing debate centres on whether*** *mindfulness apps truly foster well-being or simply gain profit from following the trend.*<br>• ***Despite its popularity***, *mindfulness* ***remains controversial because*** *it is viewed as ignoring allocating more resources to mental health.*<br>• ***The widespread adoption of*** *mindfulness in the workplace* ***has sparked disagreement over whether*** *it improves efficiency or is overhyped.* |
| *Making Claims* | • ***It is widely acknowledged that*** *mindfulness enhances self-awareness, a foundational skill for effective leadership.*<br>• ***There is no doubt that*** *mindfulness enhances emotional regulation.*<br>• ***It is clear that*** *mindfulness practices can significantly lower stress levels in high-pressure environments.* |

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| | |
|---|---|
| *Providing Evidence* (e.g., statistical data, facts, examples) | • *A **research study found** that employees who participated in corporate mindfulness programmes reported a **10% increase** in task completion speed and a **25% reduction** in errors (source).*<br>• ***Research suggests that** mindfulness meditation can reduce symptoms of anxiety by up to 20% in clinical settings (source).*<br>• *Mindfulness as a practice **originated** from Buddhist meditation traditions about **2,500 years ago**, and its integration into Western clinical practice **began in 1979** when Dr. Jon Kabat-Zinn established a Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction programme at the University of Massachusetts Medical School.*<br>• ***If** mindfulness were truly effective, **(then)** there would be fewer stressed employees in companies.* |
| *Giving Explanations* (e.g., elaboration/ reasoning) | • ***The underlying idea here is** that noticing your thoughts without reacting to them helps reduce stress.*<br>• *Counting breaths during meditation helps. **This works because** it gives your mind one thing to focus on.*<br>• *People say 'take three deep breaths' when stressed. **The logic behind this is** that deep breathing tells your body to relax.*<br>• *When you observe your thoughts without judgement, you create mental distance from them, preventing emotional escalation. **This is why** studies show mindfulness lowers cortisol levels.*<br>• *Focussing on the breath tells your body to relax because deep breaths switch on your body's 'calm down' system, lowering your heart rate. **This is what** helps reduce anxiety.*<br>• *Mindfulness teaches us to observe thoughts without judgement. When we notice anxious thoughts but don't react to them, our stress response weakens over time. **Consequently**, regular practitioners often feel calmer in daily life.*<br>• *Mindfulness meditation trains the brain to stay present. **As a result**, people often find it easier to concentrate at work.* |

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# Part 2 – Summarising Key Information and Main Ideas

**Purpose of this Section**: You will learn to summarise the speaker's main idea in different parts of a discussion.

## Activity 2.1: Summarising Skills

**Step 1**: Refer to the tapescript in Activity 1.2 (page 6), list the main ideas that you believe are essential for the summary.

**Step 2**: Listen carefully to Jacky's summary of the original recording. While listening, write down his main points. After listening, discuss the following questions:

- How is his summary structured? Does it follow the original argument's structure?
- How was the main idea extracted from the original? What was included as essential? What was omitted?

**Step 3**: Compare Jacky's main ideas with yours. Which one (Jacky's or yours) is better? Why?

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**Step 4**: Study Jacky's summary below. Could you identify any summarisation techniques (e.g., paraphrasing, generalisation)? Are they effective?

**Tapescript**

The extract discusses mindfulness. It's basically paying attention to your current body condition and feelings on purpose and without judgement. It has become popular in recent years because it's accessible and doesn't require much time. The speaker suggests that by practising mindfulness, employees' productivity will be increased because they can stay more focussed at work. Research shows that mindfulness can reduce stress and improve focus. Additionally, it's still effective even if you only have little time. As a result, employees are more efficient and make fewer mistakes.

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**Step 5**: After listening to the following recording, prepare a one-minute summary using the following expressions where appropriate.

**Other Useful Expressions**

| | |
|---|---|
| Context and Focus | • *The speaker discusses…*<br>• *This extract is about…*<br>• *The speaker defines [key term] as…* |
| Claim | • *The speaker suggests…*<br>• *The speaker claims that…*<br>• *The speaker's argument is…* |
| Evidence (e.g., statistical data, facts, examples) | • *Research shows…*<br>• *This is backed up by…*<br>• *The speaker illustrates this point with the example of …*<br>• *[He/she] cites … to support the claim* |
| Explanations (e.g., elaboration/ reasoning) | • *The underlying idea here is that…*<br>• *This works because…*<br>• *This is why…*<br>• *As a result, …* |

**Step 6**: Work in pairs. Share your summary with your partner. After sharing, give each other feedback on the *Summarisation Techniques*, such as *paraphrasing*, *generalising*, and *omission*.

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## Activity 2.2: Practise Preparing a Summary

**Step 1**: Work in pairs. Share your experience of using any GenAI platforms to support your study. Given their lack of transparency, will you trust their outputs? Why or why not?

**Step 2**: Listen carefully to the recording. While listening, take notes by completing the table below.

| | |
|---|---|
| Context and Focus | |
| Claim | |
| Evidence (e.g., statistical data, facts, examples) | |
| Explanation (e.g., elaboration/ reasoning) | |

**Step 3**: Work in pairs. Compare your notes with your partner. Take turns to present your summary.

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## Activity 2.3: Evaluating a Sample Summary

**Step 1**: Listen carefully to Tom's summary of the original recording. While listening, write down his main points. After listening, evaluate his summary using the rubric below.

### Rubric for Critical Response to Academic Arguments

**Summary Accuracy (40%)** (Coverage of Main Ideas, Precision and Avoidance of Misinterpretation)

| A/ A- | B+ / B / B- | C+ / C / C- | D or below |
|---|---|---|---|
| • Includes all the main ideas from the argument in the recording<br>• Free from personal bias or unsupported claims<br>• No distortion, exaggeration, or oversimplification of the original meaning of main ideas | • Captures most of the main ideas<br>• No personal views are included<br>• May include some unnecessary details<br>• May contain minor inaccuracies only in wording or emphasis but no major misinterpretation of main ideas | • Omits multiple main ideas<br>• May occasionally include personal views<br>• Includes some unnecessary details<br>• Includes irrelevant details or unsupported claims<br>• Contains some inaccuracies resulting in misinterpretation or distortion of the original meaning of main ideas | • Makes significant omissions or misinterprets main ideas<br>• Includes irrelevant details<br>• May fabricate claims not present in the source |

**Comment:**

**Step 2**: Work in pairs. Discuss the strengths and weaknesses of Tom's summary and improve it.

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**Step 3**: Listen carefully to Jacky's summary of the original recording. While listening, write down his main points. After listening, evaluate his summary using the rubric below.

## Rubric for Critical Response to Academic Arguments

**Summary Accuracy (40%)** (Coverage of Main Ideas, Precision and Avoidance of Misinterpretation)

| A/ A- | B+ / B / B- | C+ / C / C- | D or below |
|---|---|---|---|
| • Includes all the main ideas from the argument in the recording<br>• Free from personal bias or unsupported claims<br>• No distortion, exaggeration, or oversimplification of the original meaning of main ideas | • Captures most of the main ideas<br>• No personal views are included<br>• May include some unnecessary details<br>• May contain minor inaccuracies only in wording or emphasis but no major misinterpretation of main ideas | • Omits multiple main ideas<br>• May occasionally include personal views<br>• Includes some unnecessary details<br>• Includes irrelevant details or unsupported claims<br>• Contains some inaccuracies resulting in misinterpretation or distortion of the original meaning of main ideas | • Makes significant omissions or misinterprets main ideas<br>• Includes irrelevant details<br>• May fabricate claims not present in the source |

**Comment:**

**Step 4**: Work in pairs. Discuss the strengthens and weaknesses of Jacky's summary and improve it.

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# Part 3 – Rebuttals

**Purpose of this Section**: Many students hesitate to challenge others' views in discussions, often avoiding disagreement. However, practising rebuttals builds the confidence to defend one's stance with reasoned evidence. By learning to analyse arguments, identify weaknesses, and craft logical counterpoints, you will be able to evaluate evidence, detect biases, and avoid flawed reasoning. This not only deepens discussions but also leads to stronger solutions, as ideas are rigorously evaluated against opposing perspectives. Since the *Critical Response to Academic Arguments* (CRAA) assignment only requires you to form a counterargument without a response to that counterargument, the term 'rebuttal' in this module refers to the counterargument you form to counter the opposite argument.

## Activity 3.1: Brainstorming about Virtual Influencers

**Step 1**: Have you heard of the term "virtual influencer"? How is it related to our daily lives?

**Step 2**: Watch a video to learn more about virtual influencers and how they influence our daily lives.

(https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PKCPyq-6n9Q&t=4s)

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**Step 3**: Read a blog excerpt titled "*The Perils and Promises of Virtual Influencers: Where EU Consumer Law Falls Short*" to understand growing concerns about virtual influencers.

Social media influencers play a significant role in today's online advertising campaigns. They are independent third-party endorsers who leverage their social media pages to provide targeted recommendations about the goods or services of other enterprises. A Belgian study has indicated that influencer marketing has a significant impact on the transactional decision-making of social media users, especially among youth. Recently, some companies, including Morphe, have been turning away from human influencers, due to their high costs and unpredictability. The companies often lack control over the messages conveyed by influencers, sometimes provoking controversies.

Amid this shift, a new type of influencer has emerged: virtual influencers—online personas brought to life through computer-generated imagery (CGI)—that employ anthropomorphism to come across eerily human-like. Sometimes they are referred to as AI-influencers, even though they might not necessarily use AI imageries. It is claimed that virtual influencers generate three times more engagement with brands than their human counterparts. The most prominent virtual influencer is Lil Miquela, a musician and arts student that has gained about 2.5 million followers, and makes a considerable amount of profit for her creators by 'modelling' clothing for brands such as Prada and Calvin Klein. In 2018, TIME even named her one of the 25 most influential 'people' on the internet. She joins an army of upcoming virtual influencers, including the Swedish Esther Olofsson and Belgian Bobbi Lee.

While virtual influencers might be an attractive marketing tool, they pose a significant danger to consumers, due to a lack of authenticity. Their product endorsements are by definition ingenuine and fabricated, as virtual influencers cannot exercise an independent judgement like humans can, and they lack the physical senses that are necessary to try on clothing, feel the texture of makeup on their skin, or perceive the fragrance of a scent. Moreover, a virtual influencer showcasing clothing may not accurately depict how the garments would appear on a real person. In the same vein, Lil Miquela cannot taste the Haribo candy she promotes. Instead, brands dictate the product endorsement that virtual influencers convey, while their message is portrayed as based on their own experience. Considering the implemented level of anthropomorphism of virtual influencers, one cannot reasonably argue that consumers uphold a different standard of expectations for them as opposed to human influencers, since 42 percent of Gen Z and millennials are unable to distinguish real from unreal online personalities in absence of proper disclosure in this respect.

Source: https://blogs.law.ox.ac.uk/oblb/blog-post/2024/11/perils-and-promises-virtual-influencers-where-eu-consumer-law-falls-short

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**Step 4**: Work in pairs. In light of the concerns raised in the blog, discuss with your partner whether it is necessary to regulate virtual influencers. List your arguments in the table below.

| **It is necessary to regulate virtual influencers** | **It is unnecessary to regulate virtual influencers** |
|---|---|
| Claim:<br><br>Evidence:<br><br>Explanation: | Claim:<br><br>Evidence:<br><br>Explanation: |

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## Activity 3.2: Forming Strong Counterarguments

In Module 3 (Activity 2.6), you learned some strategies to formulate counterarguments. Below is a summary of the strategies and the associated templates.

| Strategy | Template |
|---|---|
| **1. Concession + Counterargument (The "Yes, But…" Approach)** | *"While there is some truth in the idea/belief that [opposing claim], this overlooks/fails to account for [key flaw/limitation]. In reality, [your response] because [evidence/logic]."* |
| **2. Evidence-Based Counterargument** | *"Proponents argue [opposing claim], but [authority/study] casts serious doubt on this claim/calls this claim into question. Their research shows [contradictory evidence], undermining the view/claim that [paraphrase of opposing claim]."* |
| **3. Exposing Logical Flaws** | *"This argument assumes [flawed premise], but it ignores [critical factor]. For example, [specific counterexample], which seriously undermines the claim."* |
| **4. Alternative Solutions** | *"Instead of [opposing solution], we could [better alternative], which achieves [shared goal] without [negative consequence]."* |
| **5. Questioning Relevance or Scope** | *"The claim that [opposing view] is irrelevant/misleading because [context difference]. Unlike [their example], [your topic] involves [key distinction]."* |
| **6. Ethical or Value-Based Counterargument** | *"Even if [opposing claim], it is unethical to [harmful action] because [core value]. For instance, [example of harm]."* |

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Another way to form a counterargument is to address logical fallacies in the opposing argument. Fallacies are a type of logical flaw which lead to a false conclusion.

**Step 1**: Match each fallacy in column A with its appropriate example in column B.

| A. Fallacy | B. Example |
|---|---|
| **1. Ad Hominem**<br><br>(Attacking the presenter, not the argument) | (  ) *"If we allow virtual influencers to promote products, they'll replace all human influencers. Then brands will fire real people, causing serious unemployment in the marketing industry."* |
| **2. False Dichotomy**<br><br>(Over-simplifying available options) | (  ) *"You support regulating virtual influencers because you're just a conservative who hates technology!"* |
| **3. Slippery Slope**<br><br>(Exaggerating the negative impacts) | (  ) *"We should either completely ban virtual influencers or let corporations continue to exploit consumers!"* |
| **4. Appeal to Emotions**<br><br>(Manipulating feelings over logic) | (  ) *"We should ban virtual influencers, or young, defenceless generations will be brainwashed by these fake robots!"* |
| **5. Hasty Generalisation**<br><br>(Jumping to conclusions too soon) | (  ) *"Lil Miquela promoted candy she did not taste, so it's clear that virtual influencers are frauds."* |

**Step 2**: Working in pairs, take turns to develop a counterargument to challenge one of the claims from Activity 3.1 (Step 4). Apply the strategies and point out logical fallacies covered in Activity 3.2 to strengthen your counterargument where necessary.

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## Activity 3.3: Aligning Counterarguments to the 'Core' Idea

**Step 1**: Evaluate which of the following counterarguments is valid and persuasive? Why?

**Claim (Pro-mindfulness in the workplace):**

> *"Mindfulness programmes should be implemented in workplaces because they reduce employee stress. A 2021 study found that employees who participated in an 8-week mindfulness course reported 27% lower stress levels compared to the control group. Lower stress leads to better decision-making and fewer burnout-related absences. That's why mindfulness is a cost-effective wellness training for employees."*

Counterargument 1:

> *"While mindfulness may reduce stress for some, its effects are inconsistent across workplace environments. A study in occupational health science in 2023 revealed that the employees in high-pressure industries (e.g., finance) found minimal stress reduction from mindfulness programmes because systemic job demands overpower individual coping strategies. Without addressing root causes of stress (e.g., heavy workload, poor management), mindfulness alone is insufficient."*

Counterargument 2:

> *"Companies should prioritise workload management over mindfulness, as excessive tasks are the real stressor. A research report found that 80% of employee stress stems from unrealistic deadlines, not lack of mindfulness. Reducing overtime while improving staffing will more effectively lower stress than introducing mindfulness programmes in workplaces."*

Counterargument 3:

> *"Mindfulness studies often exclude high-turnover industries. For example, most recent research studies primarily targeted at the employees with stable jobs. In fact, stress reduction may not apply to gig workers or seasonal employees who lack time for consistent practice."*

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**Step 2**: Now, you have learned that a valid and persuasive counterargument needs to directly target the 'core' idea of the opposing argument. To practise, identify the core idea of the following claims taken from the claims covered earlier.

Lillian's claim in Activity 1.2:

> *"One key reason mindfulness increases employees' productivity is that it helps them remain focussed on their tasks."*

Grace's claim in Activity 2.1:

> *"A common criticism of corporate mindfulness programmes is that it shifts the burden of well-being onto the employee and let the companies off the hook."*

Sharon's claim in Activity 2.2:

> *"A big concern with using ChatGPT in education is the risk of misinformation and bias giving students inaccurate information."*

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## Activity 3.4: Practising Forming Valid Counterarguments

**Step 1**: Listen to the recording about whether it is necessary to regulate virtual influencers. While listening, write down the main argument. After listening, develop a valid and persuasive counterargument which targets at the 'core' idea of the argument.

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**Step 2**: Continue to listen to the recording about whether it is necessary to regulate virtual influencers. While listening, write down the main argument. After listening, develop a valid and persuasive counterargument.

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## Activity 3.5: Evaluating Sample Counterarguments

**Step 1**: Listen carefully to Jacky's counterargument to Grace's argument. While listening, write down his main points. After listening, evaluate his counterargument using the rubric below.

**Counterargument Quality (30%)** (Logic, Evidence, Persuasiveness)

| A/ A- | B+ / B / B- | C+ / C / C- | D or below |
|---|---|---|---|
| • Counterargument successfully addresses the argument<br>• Grounds are highly effective in supporting the claim | • Counterargument addresses the argument<br>• Grounds are generally effective in supporting the claim | • Counterargument attempts to address the argument<br>• Grounds are sometimes effective in supporting the claim | • Counterargument does not address the argument or is not attempted<br>• Minimal grounds used |

**Comment:**

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**Step 2**: Listen carefully to Tom's counterargument to Lillian's argument. While listening, write down his main points. After listening, evaluate his counterargument using the rubric below.

**Counterargument Quality (30%)** (Logic, Evidence, Persuasiveness)

| A/ A- | B+ / B / B- | C+ / C / C- | D or below |
|---|---|---|---|
| • Counterargument successfully addresses the argument<br>• Grounds are highly effective in supporting the claim | • Counterargument addresses the argument<br>• Grounds are generally effective in supporting the claim | • Counterargument attempts to address the argument<br>• Grounds are sometimes effective in supporting the claim | • Counterargument does not address the argument or is not attempted<br>• Minimal grounds used |

**Comment:**

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# Part 4 – Strengthening Your Voice

**Purpose of this Section**: In this section, you learn to use *hedging* and *boosting* to adjust the strength of a claim to support your arguments or counterarguments.

## Activity 4.1: Awareness-Raising

**Step 1**: Rank the following three claims in order of persuasive strength (assign '3' to the strongest claim and '1' to the weakest)

| | |
|---|---|
| (  ) | *"Virtual influencers attract younger audiences on social media."* |
| (  ) | *"Some evidence suggests that virtual influencers may attract younger audiences on social media."* |
| (  ) | *"Virtual influencers overwhelmingly dominate engagement among young audiences."* |

**Step 2**: Identify any words or phrases that contribute to a claim's strength or weakness.

Step 3: Suggest when to strengthen a claim, and when to weaken a claim.

<u>Strengthen a claim when:</u>

<u>Weaken a claim when:</u>

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The table below summarises the major differences between *hedging* and *boosting*.

| | **Hedging** | **Boosting** |
|---|---|---|
| **Purpose** | Soften a claim by using cautious language | Strengthen a claim by using assertive language |
| **Uses** | • Avoid overconfidence<br>• Qualify the statement to show nuance<br>• Acknowledge uncertainty<br>• Reduce accountability if proven wrong<br>• When evidence is limited | • Make arguments more compelling<br>• Show authority<br>• Elicit action<br>• When evidence is strong<br>• Create different rhetorical effects |
| **Useful Signalling Phrases** | *"It's **possible** that..."*<br>*"Some studies **indicate**..."*<br>*"This **seems** to **suggest**..."*<br>*"It **could be argued** that..."*<br>*"This **might lead** to..."* | *"There is **no doubt** that..."*<br>*"Studies **conclusively show** that..."*<br>*"This **clearly demonstrates**..."*<br>*"This **proves** that..."*<br>*"This **will cause**..."* |

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## Activity 4.2: Practice

Strengthen the following claims using boosting techniques.

1a. *"Brands use virtual influencers for marketing campaigns."*

2a. *"Virtual influencers can reduce costs of human influencer partnerships*."

Weaken the following claims using hedging techniques.

1b. "*Brands use virtual influencers for marketing campaigns.*"

2b. *"Virtual influencers can reduce costs of human influencer partnerships*."

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# Part 5 – AI Prompts for CRAA

The following AI prompts may help you prepare for the CRAA.

| Purpose | Prompt |
|---|---|
| **1. AI provides a model response** | *"I just listened to a narration about [topic]. The background was [brief summary], the definition was [key definition], the controversy was [main argument], and the claim was [claim]. Can you give me a model 2-minute summary and a counterargument to the claim? I want to compare it with my own response."* |
| **2. AI critiques without giving answers** | *"Here's my summary and counterargument for [paste the entire narration and claim]. Point out any weaknesses in my structure, clarity, or logic without giving me a modified version."*<br><br>*"Here is my practice response. First, highlight one strength (e.g., clear structure) and one weakness (e.g., vague evidence). Then, give me a hint to improve the weakness—but don't fix it for me. I'll try to revise, and you'll tell me if I succeeded."* |
| **3. Guided Brainstorming** | *"I'm practising for my speaking test on [topic]. The claim was: '[paste the claim]'. Help me brainstorm 3 possible counterarguments, then guide me to choose the strongest one and support it logically."* |
| **4. Self-Correction Practice** | *"Here is my counterargument for [topic]. Instead of correcting it, ask me 3 questions to help me spot weaknesses in my logic or evidence."* |
| **5. Rebuttal Practice** | *"Act as a disagreeing audience member. After I give my summary of a claim and present my counterargument, challenge my counterargument. I'll respond, and you'll tell me if my response is effective."* |
| **6. Logical Flow Check** | *"Here's my summary and counterargument. Grade the logical flow from 1–5 (5=excellent) and explain where the connection between ideas gets weak."* |

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# Part 6 – Evaluating a Student Response (Mock Test)

## Activity 6.1: Brainstorming about Lab-Grown Meat

**Step 1**: Have you heard of "lab-grown meat"? Would you be willing to try it? Why or why not?

**Step 2**: Watch a video (00:01-04:00) to learn more about the latest developments in lab-grown meat.

Would you eat lab grown meat? | The Business | ABC NEWS

(https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2gxSIVa6uqY&t=1s)

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**Step 3**: Listen to the recording about whether we should further promote lab-grown meat in the future. While listening, write down the main argument. After listening, you have 2 minutes to prepare, and 2 minutes to present a summary and a counterargument of the argument in the recording.

**Step 4**: Working in pairs, take turns to develop a summary and a counterargument for one of the arguments in the recording. While your partner is presenting, use the rubric on the next page to grade his/her performance.

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## Rubric for Critical Response to Academic Arguments

**Summary Accuracy (40%)** (Coverage of Main Ideas, Precision and Avoidance of Misinterpretation)

| A/ A- | B+ / B / B- | C+ / C / C- | D or below |
|---|---|---|---|
| • Includes all the main ideas from the argument in the recording<br>• Free from personal bias or unsupported claims<br>• No distortion, exaggeration, or oversimplification of the original meaning of main ideas | • Captures most of the main ideas<br>• No personal views are included<br>• May include some unnecessary details<br>• May contain minor inaccuracies only in wording or emphasis but no major misinterpretation of main ideas | • Omits multiple main ideas<br>• May occasionally include personal views<br>• Includes some unnecessary details<br>• Includes irrelevant details or unsupported claims<br>• Contains some inaccuracies resulting in misinterpretation or distortion of the original meaning of main ideas | • Makes significant omissions or misinterprets main ideas<br>• Includes irrelevant details<br>• May fabricate claims not present in the source |

**Comment:**

**Counterargument Quality (30%)** (Logic, Evidence, Persuasiveness)

| A/ A- | B+ / B / B- | C+ / C / C- | D or below |
|---|---|---|---|
| • Counterargument successfully addresses the argument<br>• Grounds are highly effective in supporting the claim | • Counterargument addresses the argument<br>• Grounds are generally effective in supporting the claim | • Counterargument attempts to address the argument<br>• Grounds are sometimes effective in supporting the claim | • Counterargument does not address the argument or is not attempted<br>• Minimal grounds used |

**Comment:**

**Verbal Delivery (30%)** (Clarity, Pronunciation, Fluency)

| A/ A- | B+ / B / B- | C+ / C / C- | D or below |
|---|---|---|---|
| • Very clear and accurate pronunciation<br>• Highly effective use of pauses, stress and intonation<br>• High degree of preciseness of word choice and grammatical accuracy | • Clear and accurate pronunciation<br>• Effective use of pauses, stress and intonation<br>• Preciseness of word choice and grammatical accuracy | • Somewhat clear and accurate pronunciation<br>• Somewhat effective use of pauses, stress and intonation<br>• Somewhat precise in terms of word choice and grammatical accuracy | • Often unclear and inaccurate pronunciation<br>• Often ineffective use of pauses, stress and intonation<br>• Often lacking precision in terms of word choice and grammatical accuracy |

**Comment:**

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